

# YUFEI ZHANG

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Last updated: October 9, 2026

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

Health communication; large language models in social science research; social representations and stereotypes.

## EDUCATION

|                                                                                                                                   |                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| <b>Nanjing University</b><br>M.A. in Journalism and Communication (Computational Communication)<br>GPA: 4.60/5.00                 | Nanjing, China<br>2024–2027 |
| <b>Communication University of China</b><br>B.Eng. in Cyberspace Security; Minor in Computational Communication<br>GPA: 3.64/4.00 | Beijing, China<br>2020–2024 |

## PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES AND REGISTERED REPORTS

[1] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2025). Depression trajectories from mid to late life (50–89 years): The roles of cohort, multimorbidity status, and national contexts across nine European countries. *Social Science & Medicine*, 385, 118605. doi:10.1016/j.socscimed.2025.118605

[2] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Depressive symptom trajectories around the retirement transition across countries and historical periods [Stage 2 Registered Report]. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/6ypwr\_v6 Peer-reviewed and recommended by Peer Community in Registered Reports (PCI RR).

[3] Yang, Y., **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (in press). Early identification of adolescent mental health risk through integrated game-based assessment and large language model psychological inference. *The British Journal of Social Work*. Contributions: Data curation, formal analysis, and methodology.

## PREPRINTS AND MANUSCRIPTS

[1] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Psychometric comparability of LLM-based digital twins. *SSRN*. doi:10.2139/ssrn.5967255 Under review.

[2] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Loneliness from midlife to older adulthood reflects both stable trait and changing circumstance. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/7fc9v\_v1 Under review.

[3] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Digital exclusion among middle-aged and older adults in China: Age–period–cohort evidence from three national surveys, 2011–2022. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/hpv68\_v1 Under review.

[4] Yang, Y., **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Quality of life in middle and later life across Europe: Trait–occasion decomposition using the measurement-aligned SHARE CASP-12. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/hwaks\_v1 Under review. Contributions: Data curation, formal analysis, and methodology.

## CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

[1] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2025, November). Psychometric evaluation of zero-shot LLM-based digital twins from self-report data: Agreement, bias, and calibration. *2025 Annual Conference of the Jiangsu Psychological Society*. Oral presentation.

[2] Yang, Y., **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026, July). Early identification of adolescent mental health risk through integrated game-based assessment and LLM psychological inference. *Second International Workshop on Human–Machine Communication, Psychology, and Social Change*, Shenzhen University, Shenzhen, China. *Second Prize*.

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>Computational Communication Collaboratory, Nanjing University</b><br>Graduate Researcher   Supervisor: Zhihao Ma                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Nanjing, China<br>2024–Present |
| <b>Digital Twin Psychometrics and Personality Geometry in Large Language Models</b><br>• Evaluate the psychometric comparability of LLM-based digital twins and human respondents across psychological, behavioral, and open-ended text tasks.<br>• Design multi-study evaluations across models and prompting conditions to assess construct validity and human–LLM alignment using psychometric, network, calibration, and text-analytic methods.<br>• Apply representational similarity analysis and network analysis to examine personality structures represented by LLM, comparing their representational geometry and network organization with human-derived and theory-based personality structures. | Aug. 2025–Present              |

- Psychological Adaptation and Social Participation from Midlife to Later Life*

Sep. 2024–Present

  - Lead the design and analysis of cross-national longitudinal studies of how retirement transitions, cohort membership, and institutional frameworks shape inequalities in depression, loneliness, and social participation from midlife to later life, using panel data from HRS, SHARE, CHARLS and comparable national ageing surveys.
  - Apply age–period–cohort, multilevel, latent-variable, and longitudinal models to examine how socioeconomic and health disadvantage accumulates across the later life course, including digital exclusion as an emerging axis of stratification in China.
- Constructing Old Age: A Cross-National Diachronic Analysis of Aging Narratives*

Oct. 2025–Present

  - Analyze cross-national and historical changes in narratives of aging using large-scale diachronic corpora and word embeddings.
  - Examine age stereotypes and social representations through semantic association and multilevel analyses.

RESEARCH METHODS

**Statistical & Psychometric Methods:** Secondary analysis of longitudinal cohort and panel studies; longitudinal modeling; multilevel modeling; age–period–cohort analysis; structural equation modeling (SEM); psychometric analysis.  
**Computational Methods:** Natural language processing (NLP); distributional semantics (word and sentence embeddings).

TEACHING AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

|                                                                                |                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <b>Teaching Assistant, Nanjing University</b>                                  |                      |
| Computational Communication Research Training Program (Graduate Course)        | Fall 2026            |
| Causal Inference in Social Sciences (Graduate Course)                          | Spring 2026          |
| Applications of LLMs in Digital Humanities (Undergraduate Course)              | Spring 2026          |
| Social Research Methods (Undergraduate Course)                                 | Fall 2025, Fall 2026 |
| Academic Writing and Social Research Methods (Undergraduate Course)            | Spring 2025          |
| <b>Reporting Intern, Hong Kong, Macao, and Taiwan Desk, Xinhua News Agency</b> | May–Aug. 2023        |

RESEARCH GRANT

|                                                                                                  |           |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Determinants of Digital Exclusion Among Middle-Aged and Older Adults</b>                      | Nov. 2025 |
| Distinguished Talent Cultivation Program (2025GYB18)   <b>Principal Investigator</b>   CNY 6,000 |           |

SELECTED HONORS AND AWARDS

|                                                |           |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Excellent Graduate Student, Nanjing University | Dec. 2025 |
| National Scholarship for Graduate Students     | Nov. 2025 |
| First-Class Academic Scholarship               | Nov. 2025 |
| Second-Class Academic Scholarship              | Dec. 2024 |

SKILLS

Language: English (IELTS: 7.5/9; TOEFL: 5.5/6), Mandarin (Native)  
Programming: Python, R, Stata